



PIECING TOGETHER THE PERFECT HOLIDAY PIE

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PIE HAS ALWAYS INTIMIDATED ME. I've enjoyed baking for years, but the mouthwatering pies my stepmom made for our holiday desserts always seemed too daunting: the flaky golden crust, the juicy-but-not-mushy filling, the lattice designs with fruit peeking out below. I stuck to cookies, brownies, cupcakes, but not pie. That changed when the pandemic hit Washington state hard. I made my first homemade pie crust in March 2020, the week The Seattle Times started working from home. I suddenly had extra time to

fill, without commuting or going out with friends or doing much at all besides taking walks around my Phinney Ridge neighborhood. Pi Day was coming up, and I wanted a project to distract from the stress and fear of the spreading pandemic. I settled on a salted caramel apple pie with a homemade butter crust. Following an online tutorial, I figured out how to make a presentable lattice design for the top, and just like that, I'd successfully done it: a pie crust from scratch.

I took a few forays into focaccia and cake, but pie was what stuck. In those anxious times two springs ago, when everything seemed out of our control, I found comfort in the tactile process of rolling out crust, mixing up filling and assembling it all. It wasn't as tricky as I'd thought; it just took some time and patience. During Seattle's stay-home order, I made the apple pie, a lemon one and a mixed-berry variety. Over time, I got better at rolling out an even crust and baking it so it would be golden-brown but not burned. I

even started experimenting with my own adaptations and fillings, which led to the pie recipes you see here. Making pies also became a way to mark special occasions that looked different during the pandemic. The dessert is practically synonymous with American holiday celebrations, from Thanksgiving to the Fourth of July, and I embraced that in 2020. I didn't visit my family in Colorado for the holidays last year, and within the sadness of separation, there was room for new traditions. A peach pie brought summer fla-

vor to a backyard Fourth of July gathering. For a tiny Thanksgiving with my roommates, I made a caramel pear pie. Now that my social group is vaccinated, I've been able to share pie with more people (I made three for my birthday this fall). I'll be able to make pie for Thanksgiving with my family this year, and I won't take that for granted. I've been at this for more than a year now, but remember, I'm still an amateur home baker. I'm still learning and making plenty of mistakes — just ask the photo and

video journalists who documented the following recipes. But take my advice from a year and a half of pandemic pie-making: Don't be intimidated. Enjoy the process. To show that anyone of any culinary ability level can make a pie, we've come up with these three pies of varying difficulty levels. Whether you have years of pie experience or are just beginning, try one of the following recipes to share with others over your Thanksgiving table this fall.

Ah, pie. Perhaps it will never wrestle the Thanksgiving limelight away from the mighty turkey, but pies of all flavors — apple, pumpkin, pecan — go hand in hand with the holiday season. Read on for three great recipes.

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